

# PRACTICAL MANUAL GUIDE

Step by step guide on how to frame your screen for design

By

Oluwaseun Ayanyemi

# Welcome aboard!

Welcome to *Creating the Grid System*, a practical workbook designed to turn chaotic layouts into clean, confident, and cohesive designs.

Whether you are a beginner struggling with alignment or a seasoned designer looking to systematize your workflow, this workbook will give you the structure you need. No theory overload. Just actionable steps, visual exercises, and real layout challenges.

# Mastering the Grid

Grids are the invisible backbone of great design. They bring order to creativity, helping you:

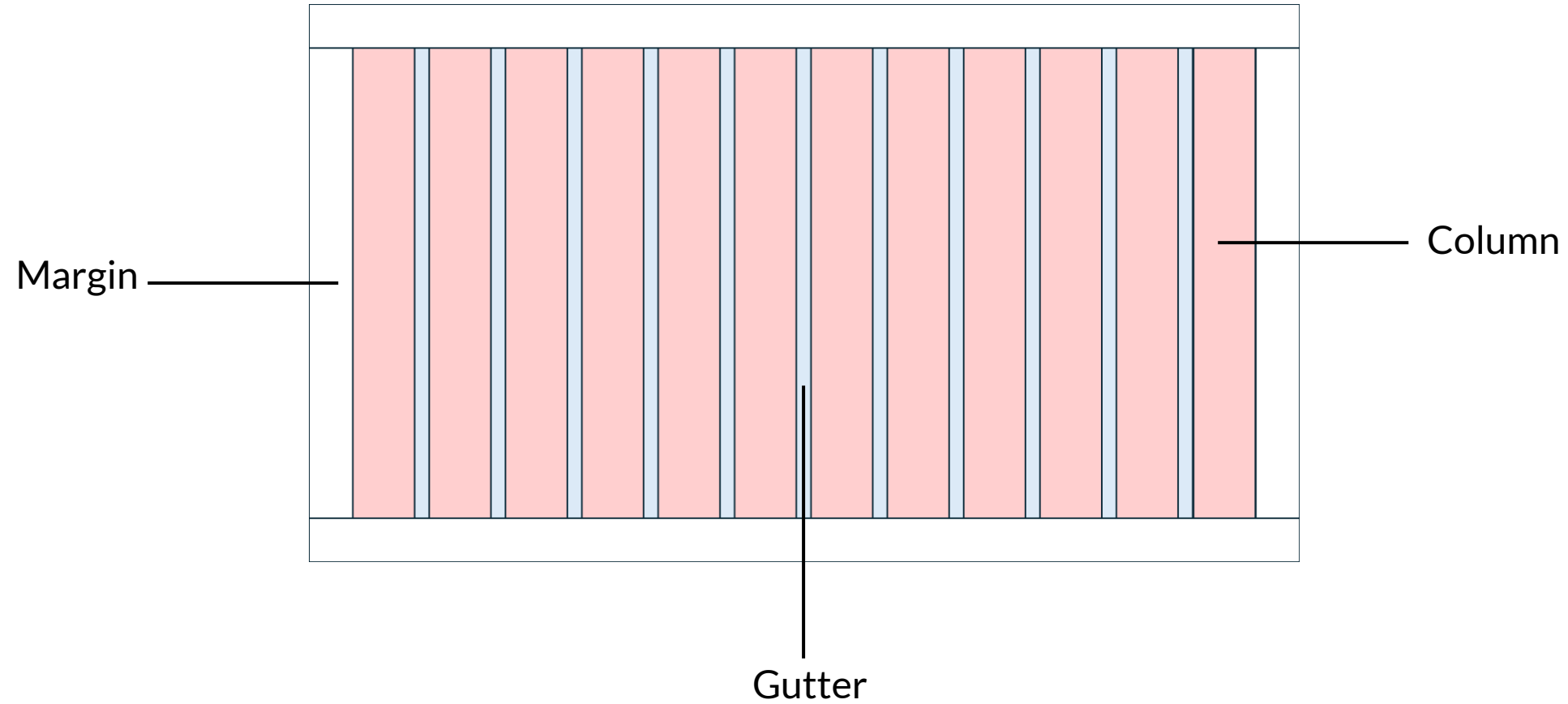
- Establish visual hierarchy
- Improve readability and flow
- Speed up your layout decisions
- Create consistency across multiple pages or screens
- Achieve that *clean, professional look* effortlessly

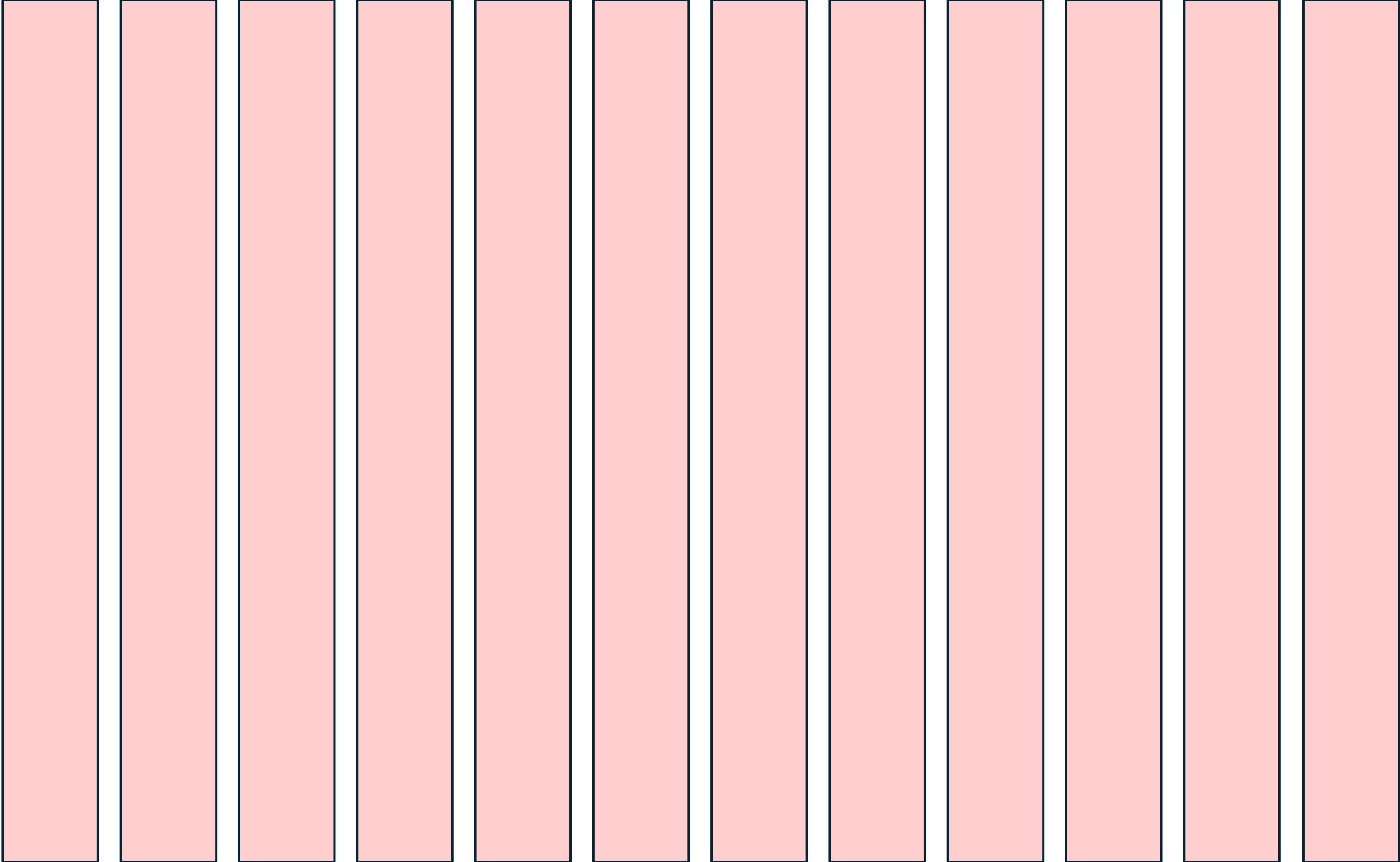
# What You Will Build

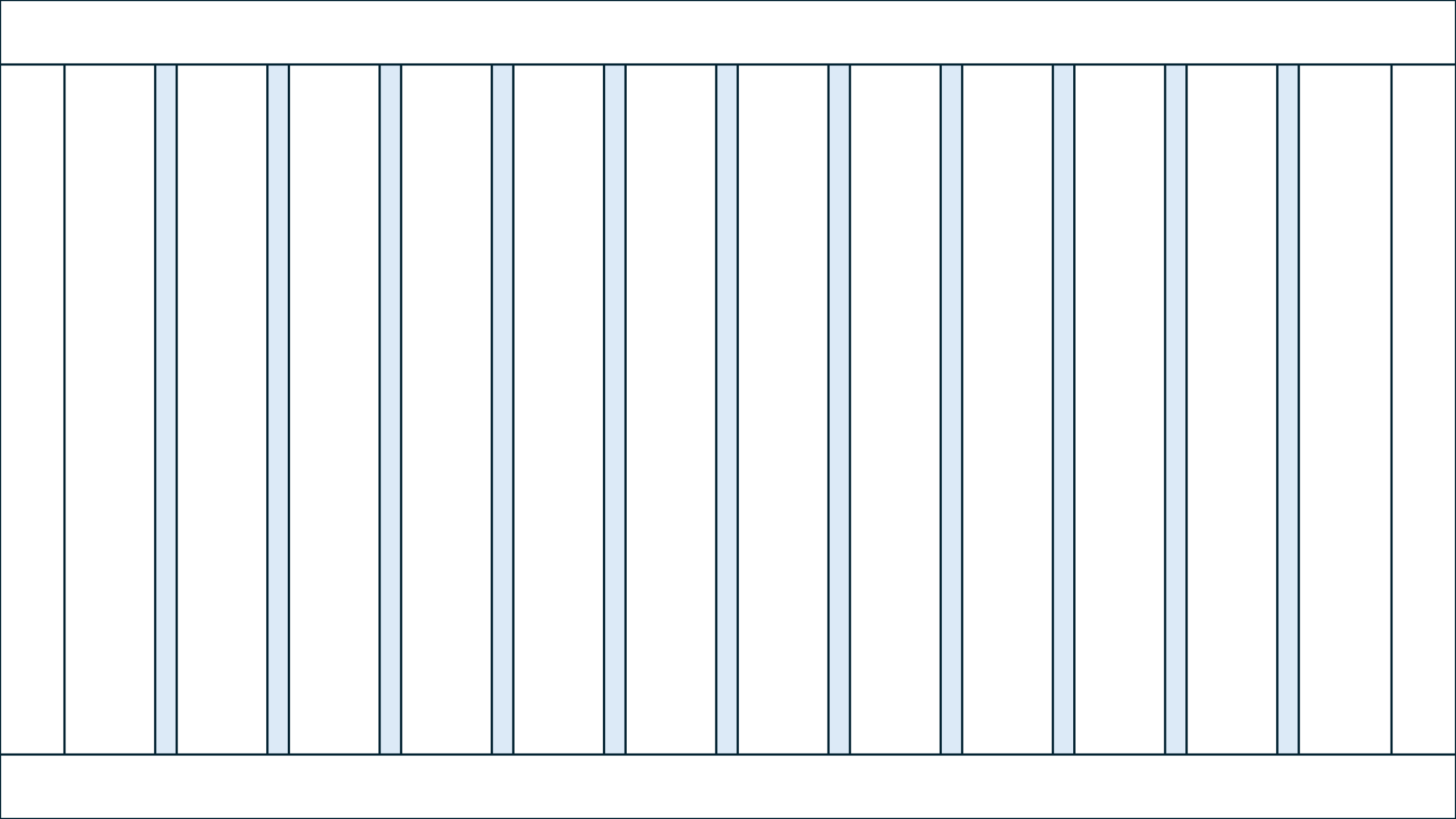
By the end of this workbook, you'll have:

- A fully documented grid system (margins, columns, gutters, baselines).
- A responsive framework for print or digital media.
- A reusable template you can apply to future projects.

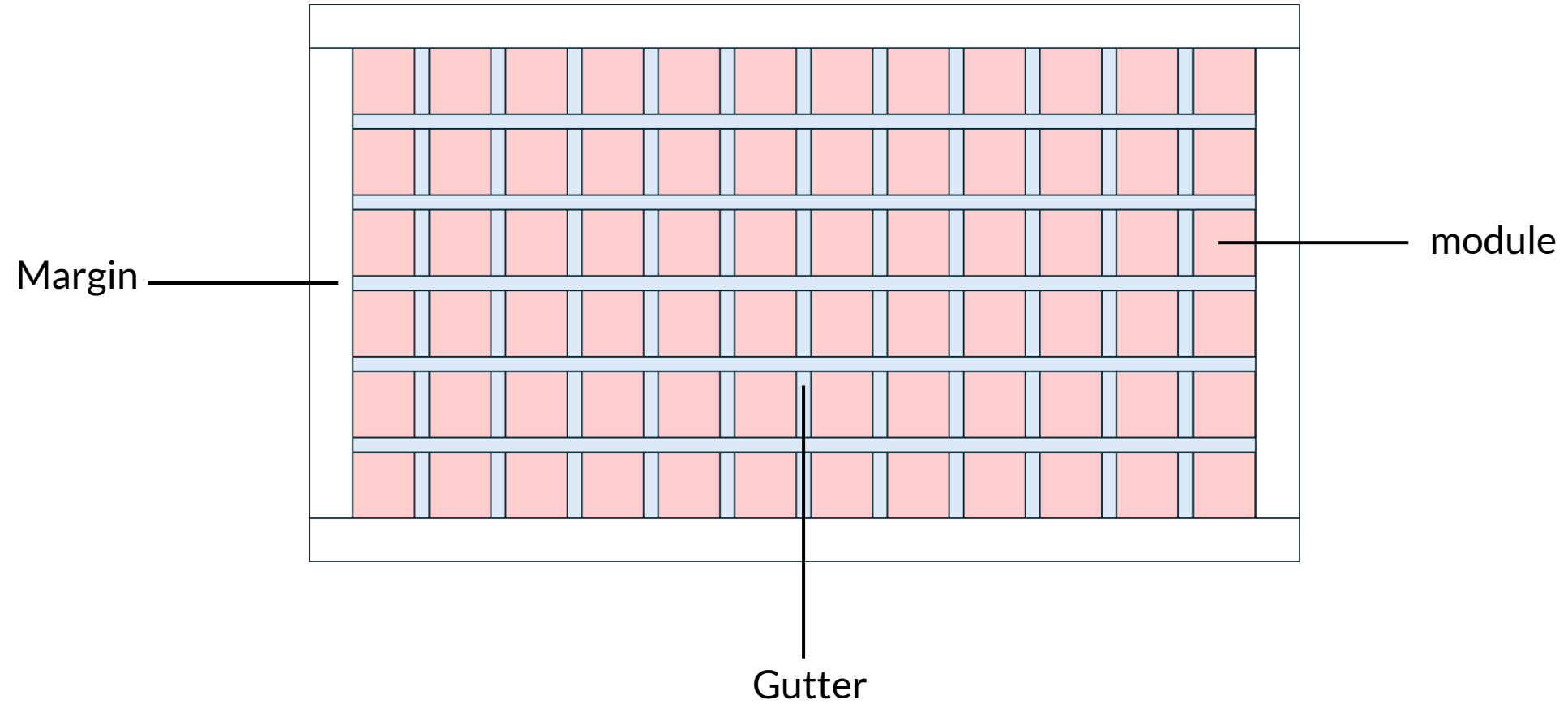
# 12-column Grid System







# 12-column Grid System





# WHAT IS A 12-COLUMN GRID

Before you build a grid, you need to understand its most popular and flexible form: the **12-column grid**.

A 12-column grid divides a layout into **12 equal-width vertical columns** (plus spaces in between called *gutters*). These columns act as guides to place text, images, buttons, and other elements in a clean, structured way.

# Creating a 12-column Grid

# A Step-by-Step Picture Guide

**Before you start:**

Open PowerPoint. Start with a **blank slide**.

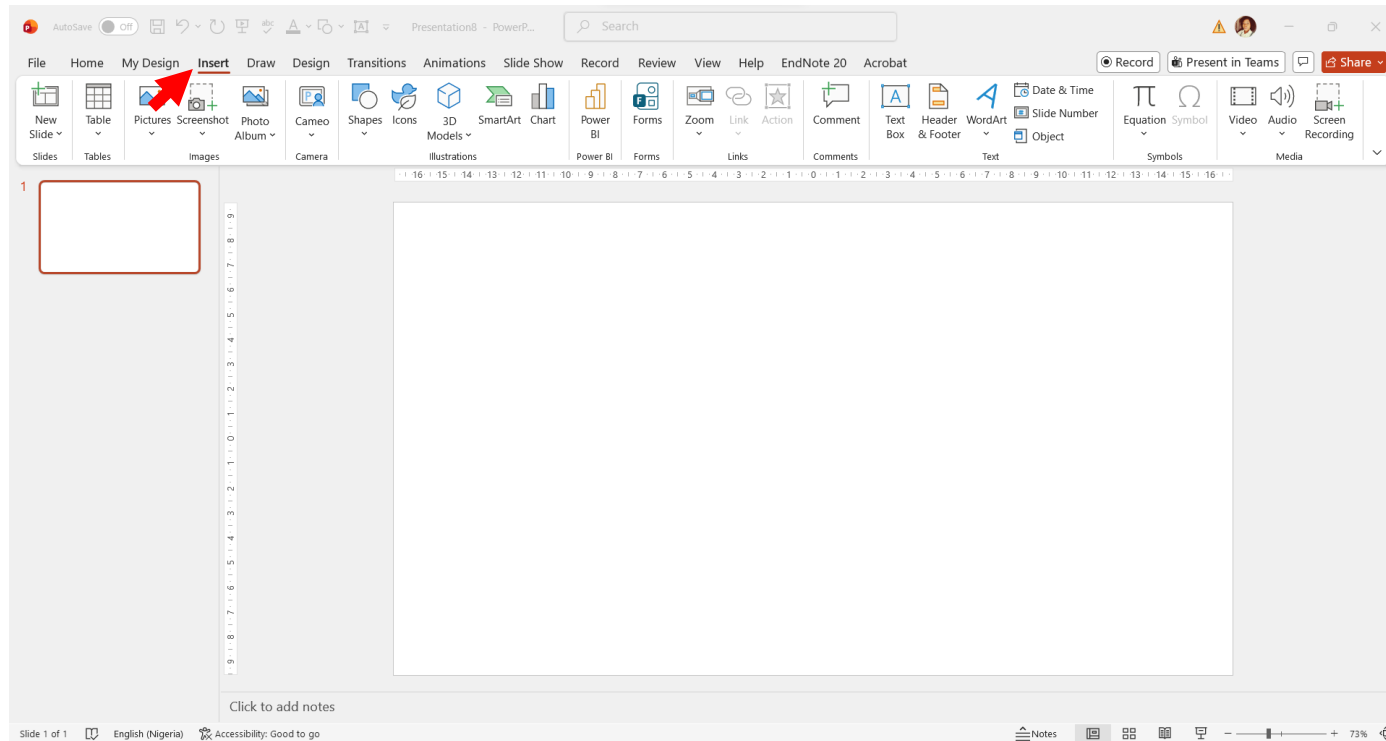
Make sure the **ruler** and **guides** are off for now (we will use only rectangles).



# STEP 1 — Find your screen size

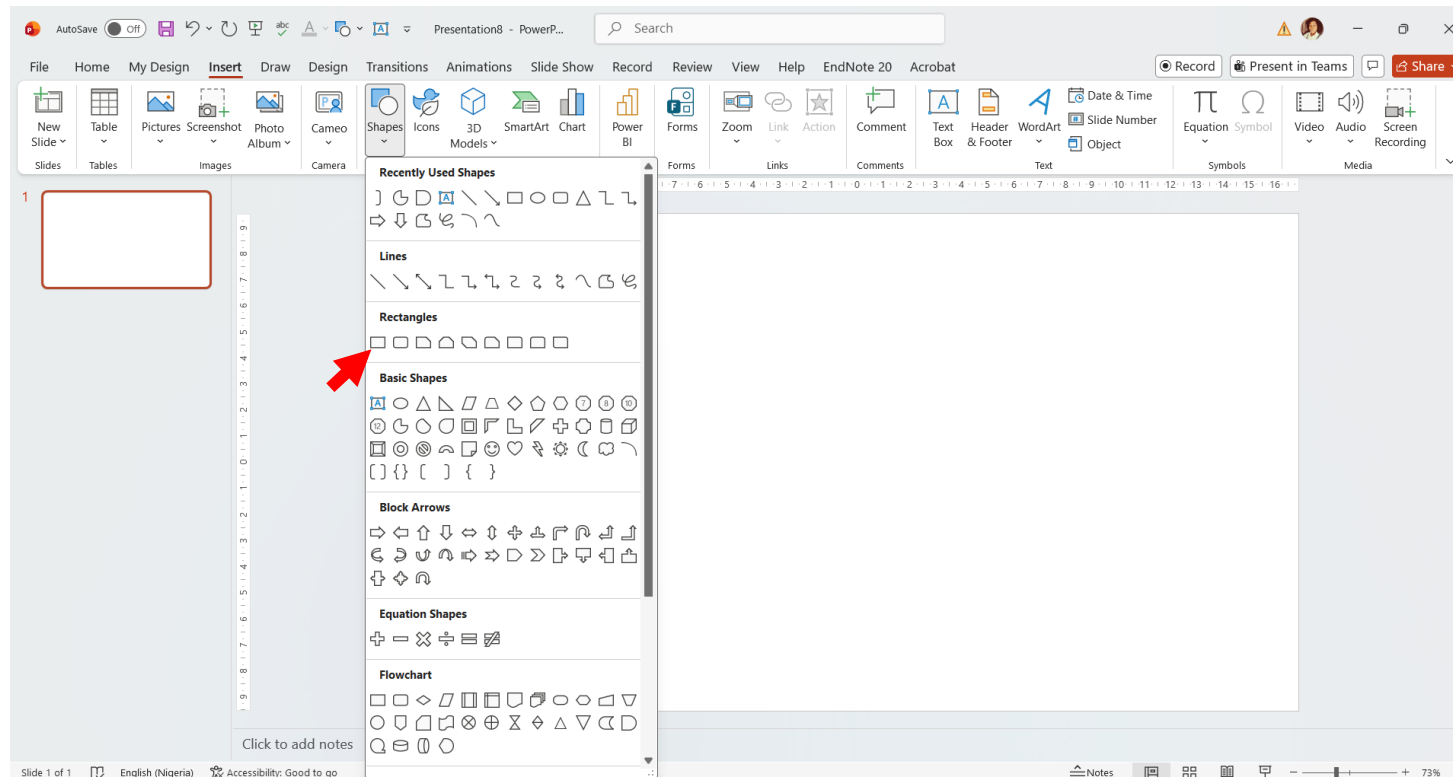
What to do:

Click on the **Insert** tab (top menu).



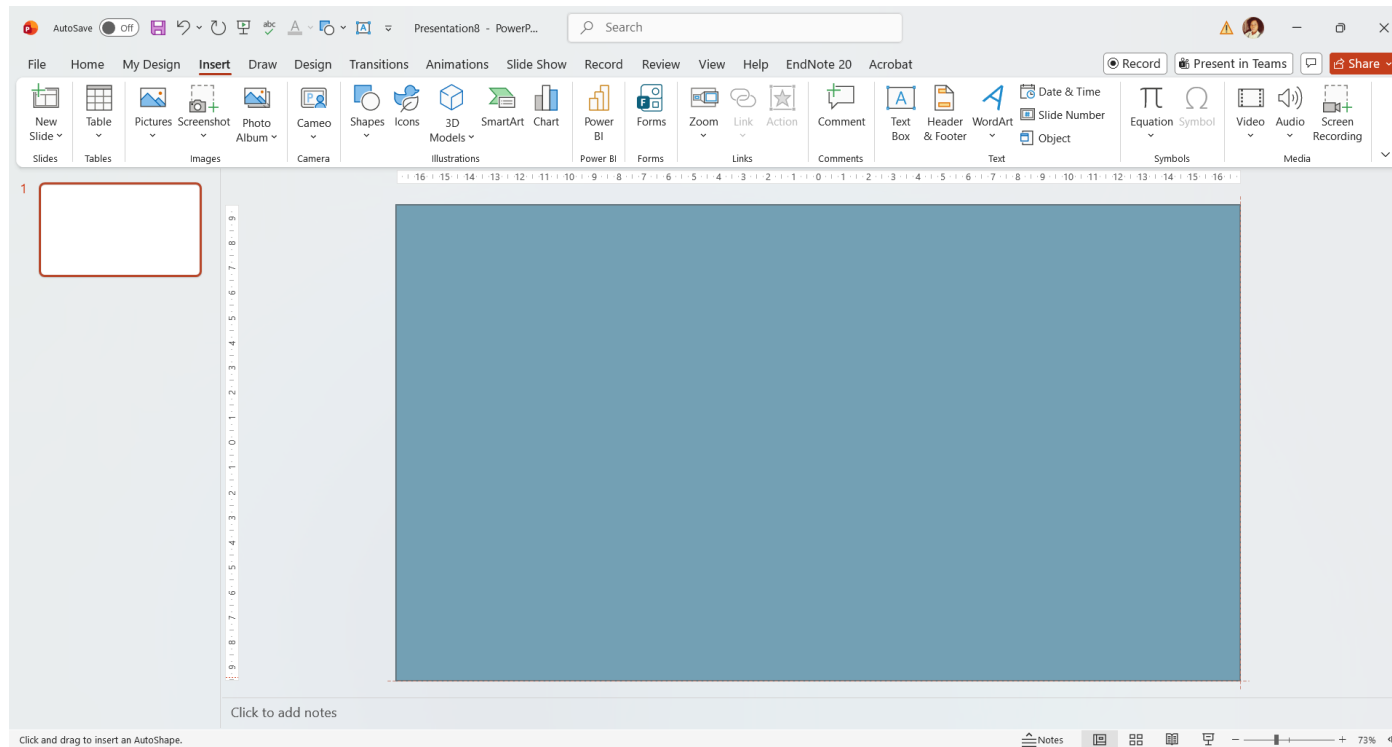
# STEP 1 — Find your screen size

Click **Shapes** → choose the **Rectangle** (first one).



# STEP 1 – Find your screen size

Draw a rectangle **over the whole slide** from top-left corner to bottom-right corner.



# STEP 1 – Find your screen size

With the rectangle selected, look at the top-right of PowerPoint window. You will see **Width** and **Height** numbers.

Write them down here:

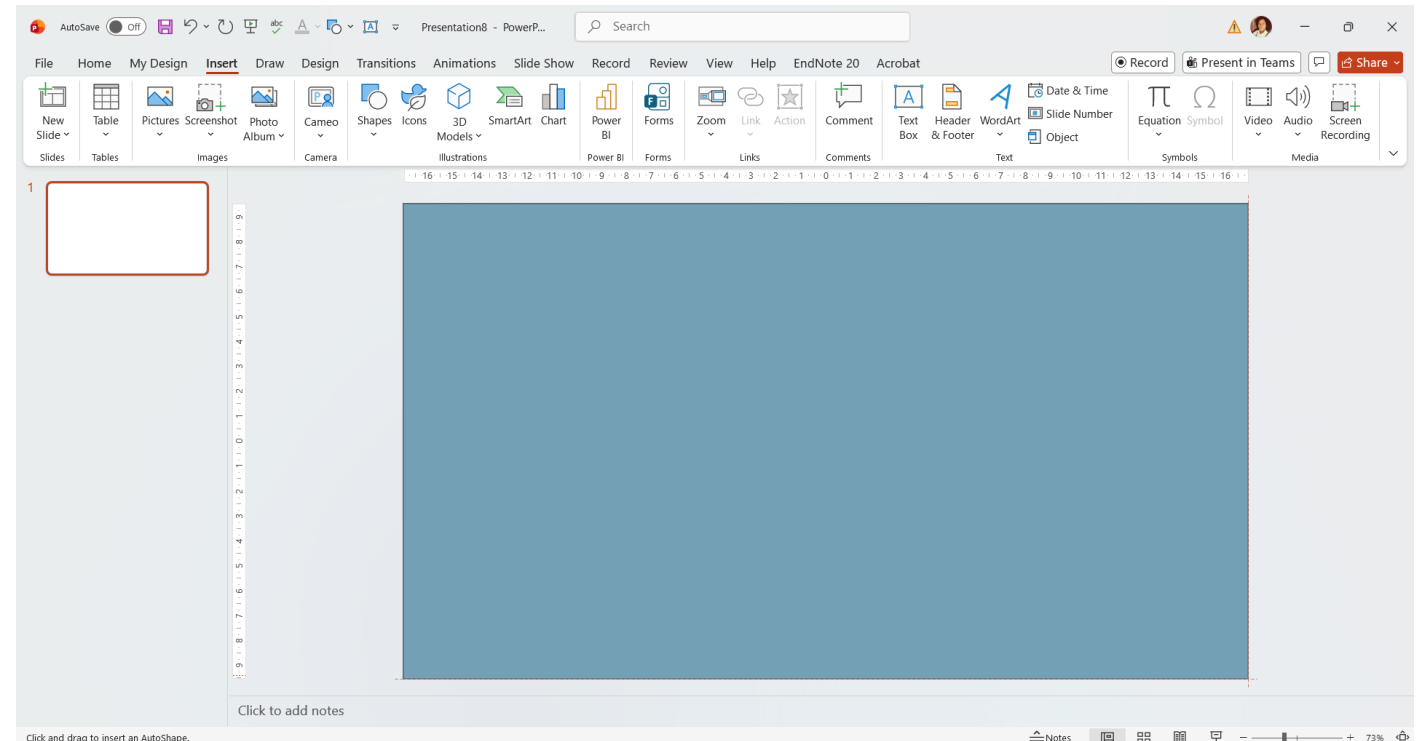
**Total width = \_\_\_\_\_ cm**

**Total height = \_\_\_\_\_ cm**

 *Example from one screen:*

Width = 33.87 cm

Height = 19.05 cm





# STEP 2 – Create your margins

Margins keep your content from touching the edge of the screen.  
We will use;

- **1.5 cm** for the **left margin**
- **1.5 cm** for the **right margin**
- **1.5 cm** for the **top margin**
- **1.5 cm** for the **bottom margin**

# STEP 2 – Create your margins

**What to do:**

**Left margin:**

Go to **Insert → Shapes → Rectangle**

Draw a tall skinny rectangle on the **left edge** of your slide.

Click on the rectangle.

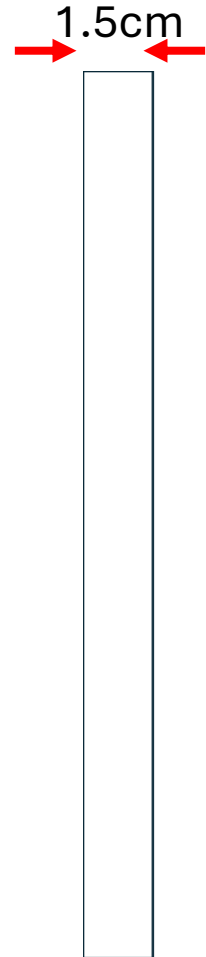
In the top-left corner (Width/Height box):

Set **Width** = **1.5 cm**

Set **Height** = **same as your total screen height** (example: 19.05 cm)

Move it so it touches the left edge perfectly.

## STEP 2 – Create your margins-one side



# STEP 2 – Create your margins

What to do:

**Right margin:**

Repeat the same steps on the **right edge**.

Width = 1.5 cm, Height = total screen height.

## STEP 2 – Create your margins- 2 sides



# STEP 2 – Create your margins

**What to do:**

**Top margin:**

Draw a short wide rectangle at the **top** of the slide.

Width = total screen width (example: 33.87 cm)

Height = 1.5 cm

**Bottom margin:**

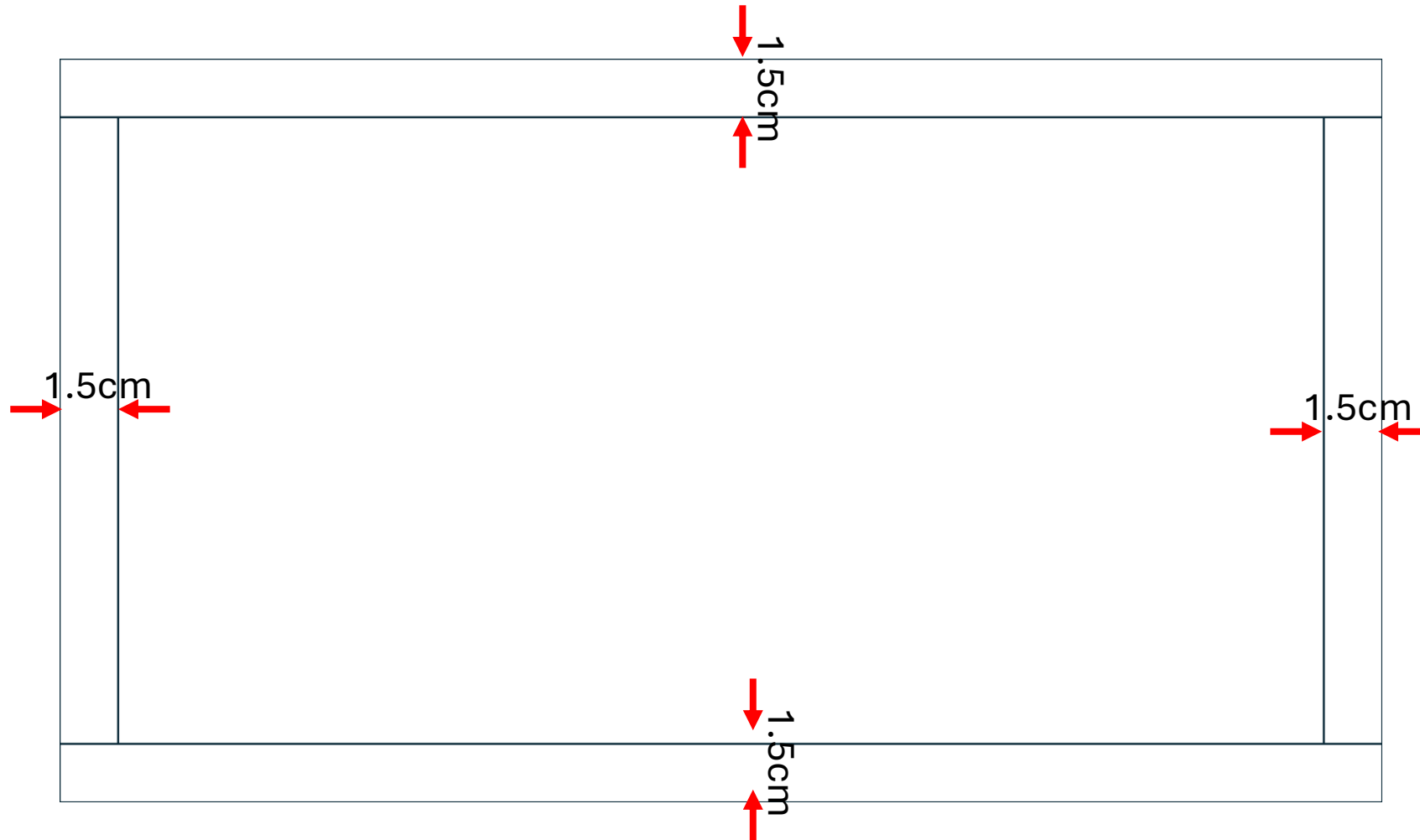
Same as top, but at the **bottom**.

Width = total screen width

Height = 1.5 cm

*Now you have four margin rectangles around your slide.*

## STEP 2 – Create your margins- 4 sides



## STEP 3- Group and color your margin

- Click on your margin rectangle and select all four, then select Ctrl on windows or command on mac and select “G” (Ctrl G to group)
- Name it “Margin”
- Go to **Shape Fill** , select margin, top right, click on shape format and select fill(top menu, paint bucket icon).
- Choose **White**.
- Repeat for all four margin rectangles.



# STEP 4 – Create your first column

- We will use:
- 12 columns
- 11 gutters (spaces between columns)
- Each gutter = 0.5 cm wide
- Column width = unknown (we calculate it)

# Formula (Skip if you are not interested)

Total width = (left margin + right margin) + (12 × column width) + (11 × gutter width)

- Example with numbers:
- $33.87 = (1.5 + 1.5) + (12 \times \text{column width}) + (11 \times 0.5)$
- $33.87 = 3 + (12 \times \text{column width}) + 5.5$
- $33.87 - 8.5 = 12 \times \text{column width}$
- $25.37 = 12 \times \text{column width}$
- Column width = 2.11 cm
-  Your column width = 2.11 cm

# STEP 4 – Create your first column

## What to do (first column):

- Insert → Shapes → Rectangle
- Draw a tall rectangle anywhere.
- Set Width = 2.11 cm
- Set Height = total screen height
- Example: 19.05
- Place it so it touches the left margin on its left side.



2.11cm

The diagram shows a large rectangular area defined by a dark blue border. On the left side, there is a vertical red strip. A dimension line with arrows at both ends is positioned to the left of the red strip, indicating its width. The text '2.11cm' is placed above the dimension line.

# STEP 5 – Create one gutter next to the column

**Insert → Shapes → Rectangle**

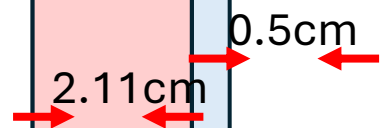
Draw a tall skinny rectangle.

Set **Width** = 0.5 cm

Set **Height** = same as column height

Place it **directly to the right** of your first column, touching it.

✓ Now you have: **[Column] [Gutter]**.



2.11cm

0.5cm

The diagram shows a vertical bar on the left side of a large rectangular frame. The bar is divided into two sections: a wider, light red section on the left and a narrower, light blue section on the right. A red double-headed arrow labeled '2.11cm' spans the width of the red section. Another red double-headed arrow labeled '0.5cm' spans the width of the blue section. The entire diagram is enclosed in a thin black rectangular border.

# STEP 6 – Duplicate to fill the whole screen

This is the magic trick to avoid drawing 12 times.

**Select both** the column and the gutter (click one, hold Ctrl, click the other).

Press **Ctrl + C** (copy)

Press **Ctrl + V** (paste)

Drag the new pair so it sits **right after** the first gutter.

Repeat paste and drag until you have **12 columns and 11 gutters**.

 *Stop when the last column touches the right margin.*

# STEP 7 – Group and Color Your column and Gutters

## **Columns:**

Click on any column rectangle.

**Shape Fill** → choose **Pink**

Transparency → **70%**

Repeat for all columns (use Ctrl+click to select multiple)

## **Gutters:**

Click on any gutter rectangle.

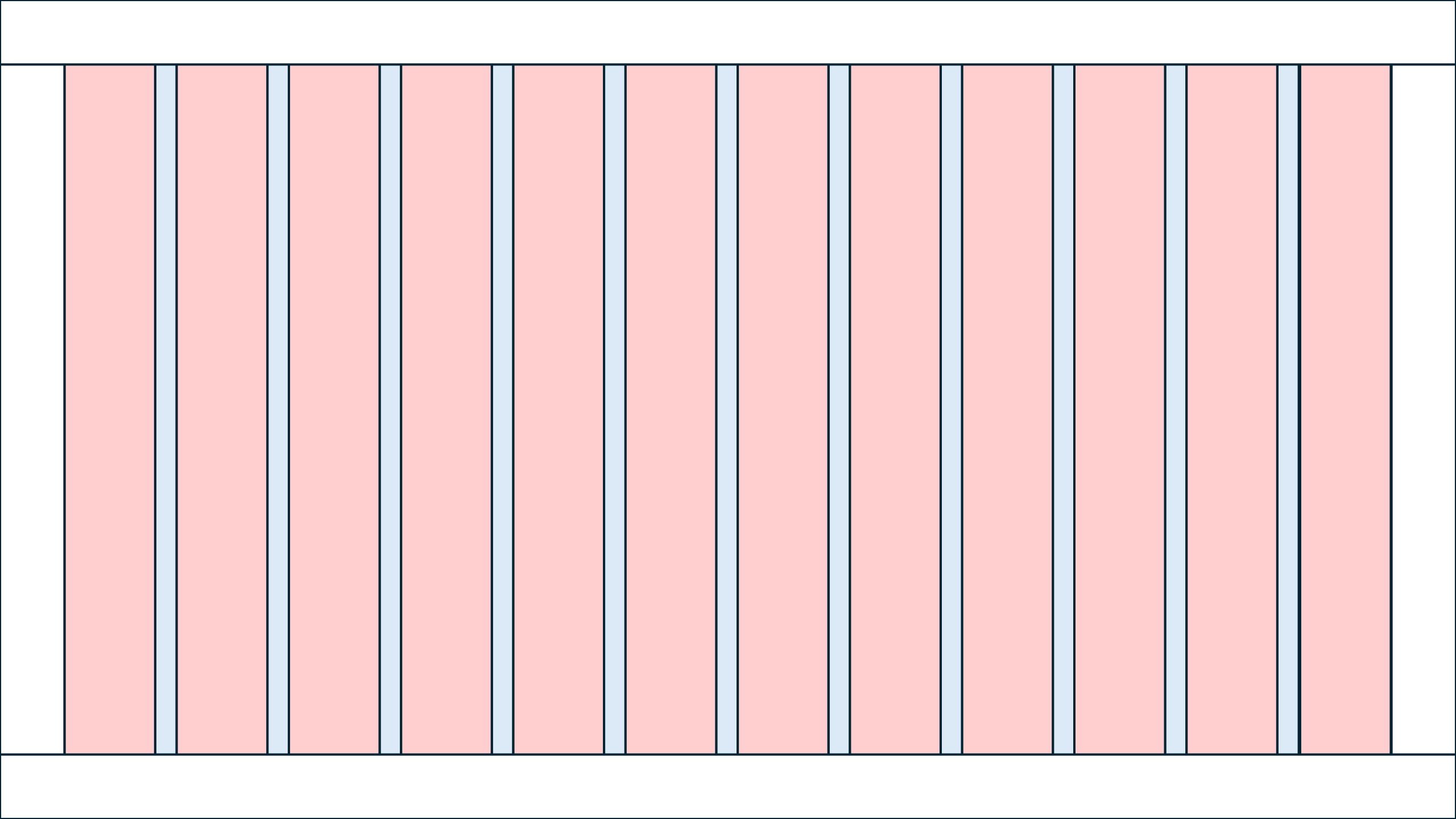
**Shape Fill** → choose **Blue**

Transparency → **70%**

Repeat for all gutters.

*Margins = white, Columns = pink, Gutters = blue, Rows (next) = no fill.*





# STEP 8 – Create Rows

We use:

**6 rows**

**5 horizontal gutters**

Gutter height = 0.5 cm

Row height = unknown

## STEP 8 – Calculate Row height (optional)

Total height = top margin + bottom margin + (6 × row height) + (5 × gutter height)

Example:  $19.05 = 3 + (6 \times \text{row height}) + (5 \times 0.5)$

$19.05 = 3 + (6 \times \text{row height}) + 2.5$

$19.05 - 5.5 = 6 \times \text{row height}$

$13.55 = 6 \times \text{row height}$

**Row height = 2.26 cm**

 **Your row height = 2.26 cm**

# STEP 8 – Create Row

**What to do:**

**Insert → Shapes → Rectangle**

Draw a short wide rectangle.

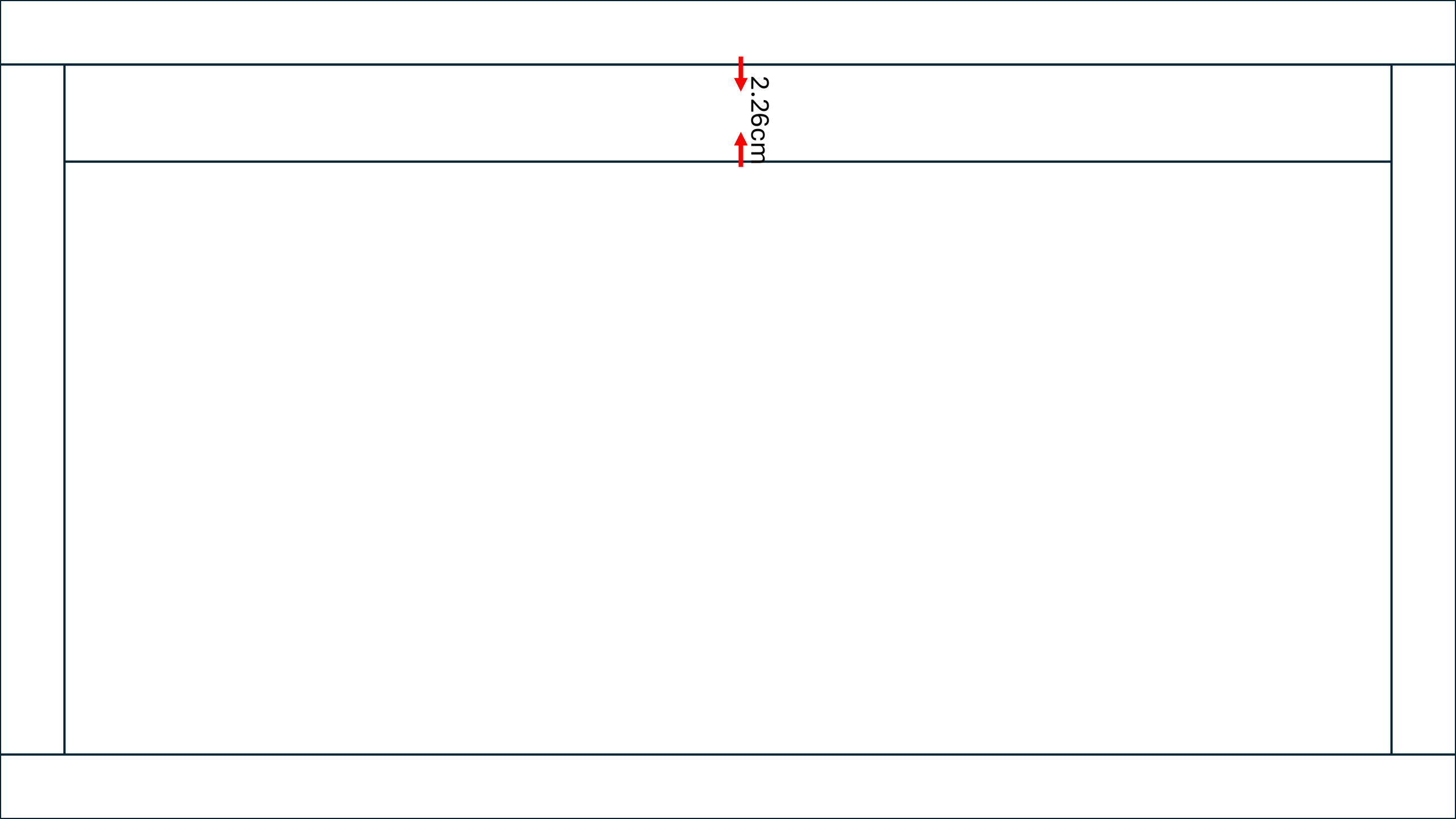
Set **Height** = **2.26 cm**

Set **Width** = **total screen width** (example: 33.87 cm)

Place it directly **below the top margin**.

**No fill** (leave transparent, or use a very light color at 70% if needed).

Repeat to make 6 rows stacked vertically, each **2.26 cm tall**, with a **0.5 cm gap** between them (that gap is your horizontal gutter, you can draw it as a thin rectangle or just leave empty space).



2.26cm

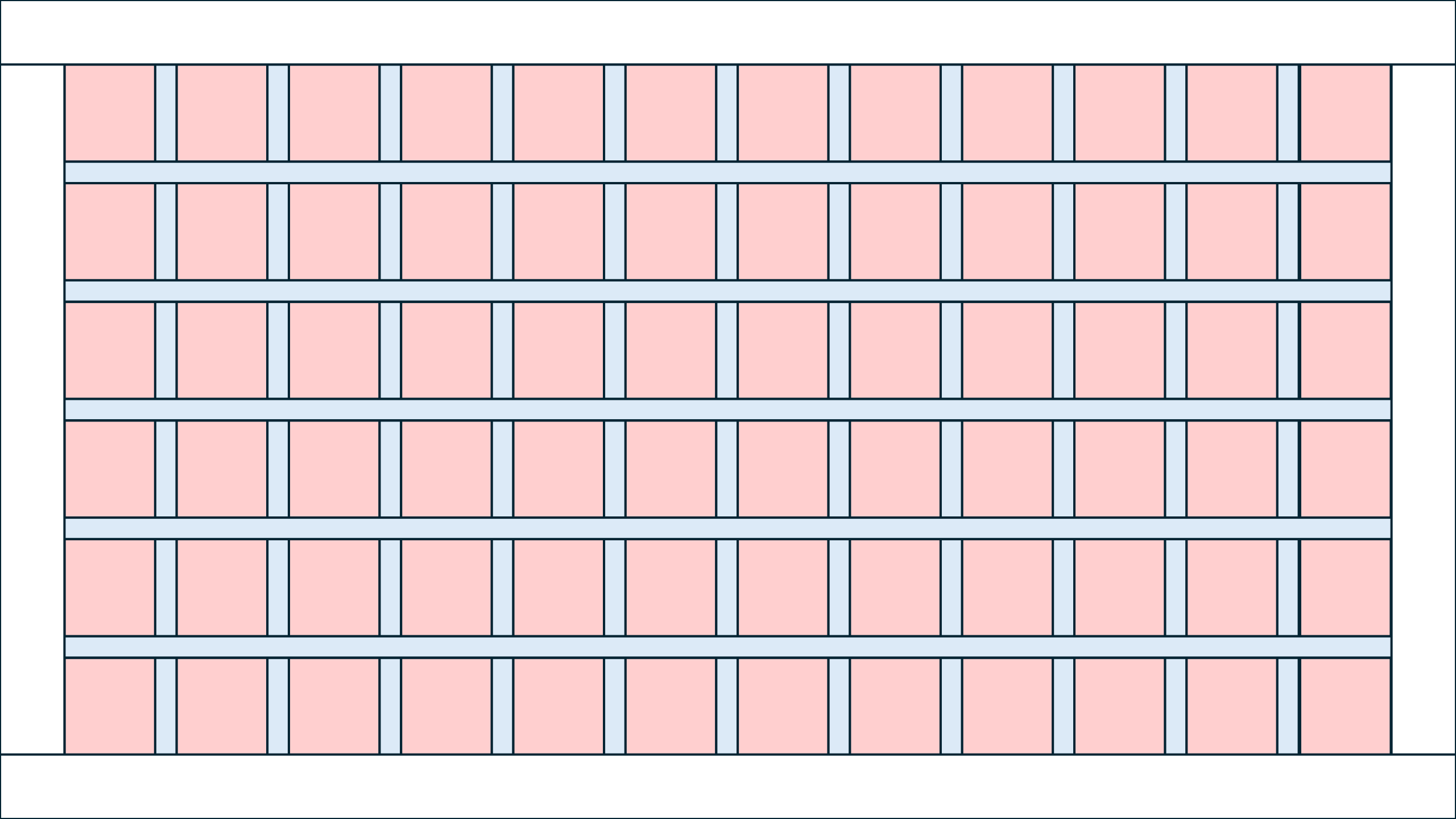
The diagram shows a large rectangular frame with a light gray background. The frame is defined by dark gray lines. A dimension line is located at the top center of the frame, consisting of two horizontal red arrows pointing towards each other, with the text '2.26cm' written vertically between them.



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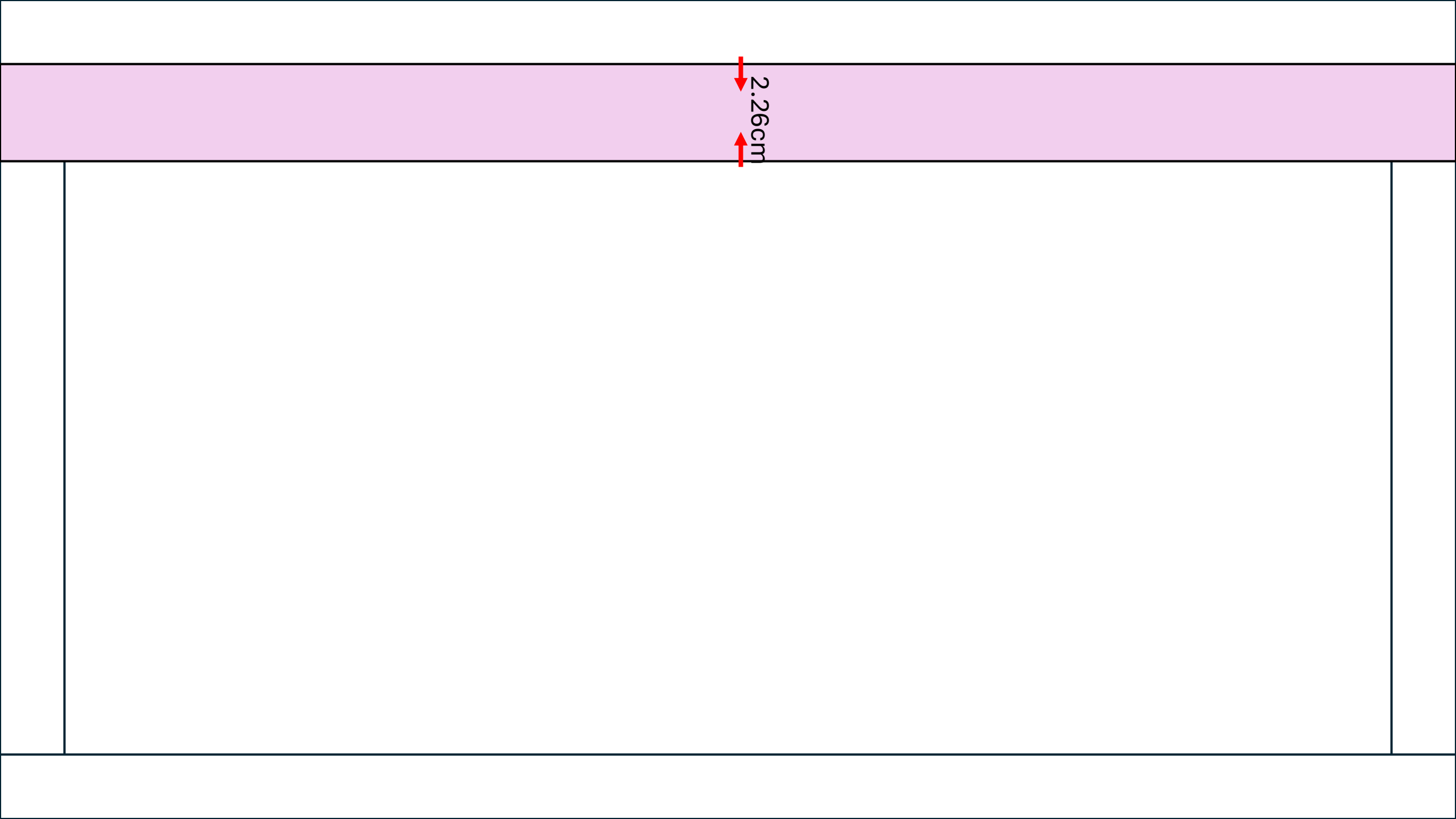
# STEP 9 – Create baseline for text alignment

A baseline helps you align text neatly inside a row.

Each row = 2.26 cm tall

Divide each row into **8 equal parts**

Each part (sub-row height) =  $2.26 \div 8 = 0.28$  cm



# STEP 9 – Create baseline for text alignment

## What to do:

Inside the **first row**, draw a very short rectangle.

Set **Height** = 0.28 cm

Set **Width** = **same as row width** (total screen width minus left and right margins)

Place it at the **top of the row** (touching the top edge of the row).

**Color** = **very light grey or no fill** (just as a guide).

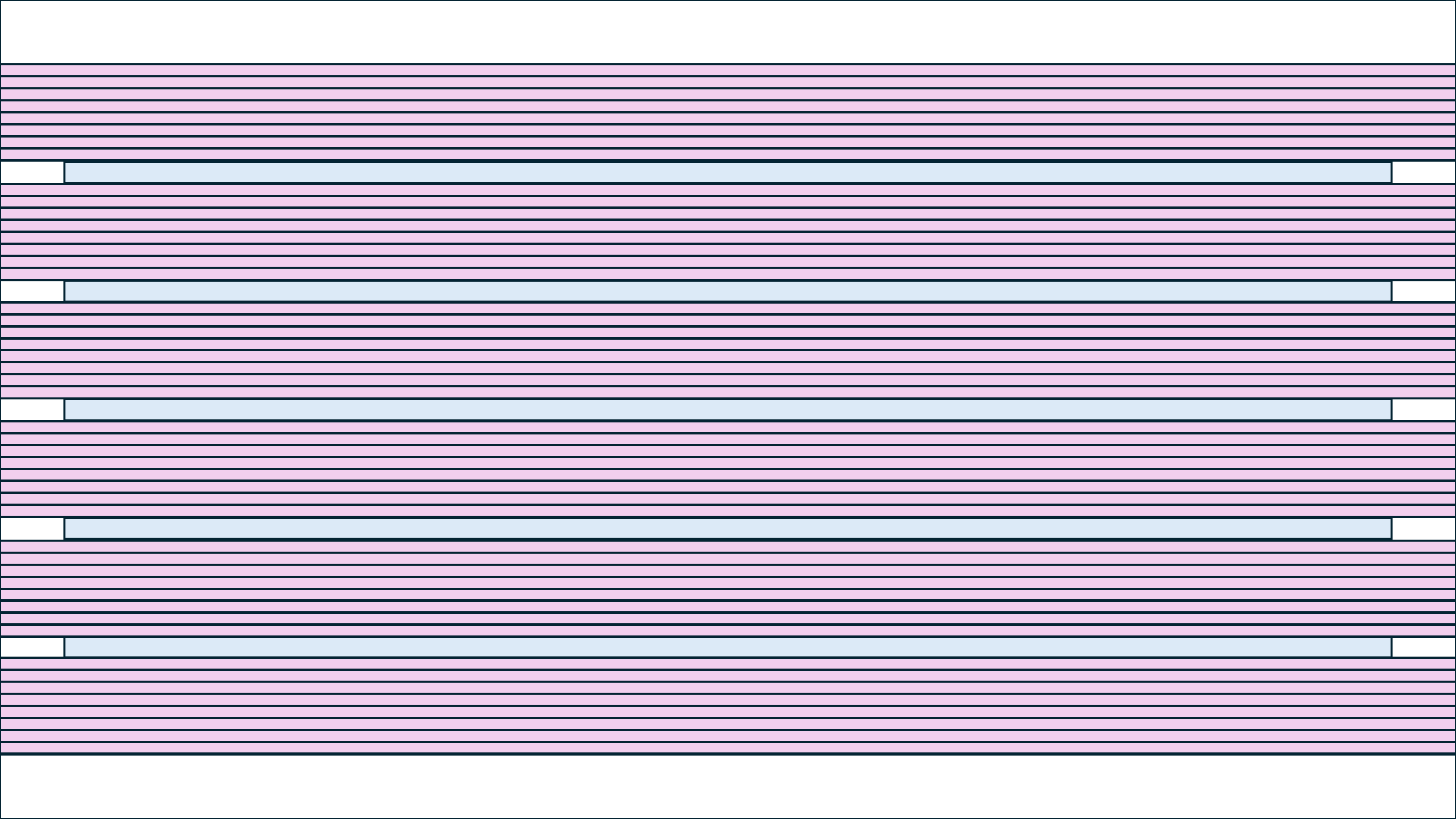
Duplicate it 7 more times inside the same row, each **0.28 cm tall**, stacked without gaps.

Repeat the same for all 6 rows.

✓ *Now every row has 8 thin baselines for your text.*

[illegible]

[illegible]



# Final Step- You are done!

## You have built:

- ✓ 1.5 cm margins (white)
- ✓ 12 columns (pink, 70%)
- ✓ 11 vertical gutters (blue, 70%)
- ✓ 6 rows (transparent)
- ✓ 5 horizontal gutters (0.5 cm each)
- ✓ Baselines inside each row (0.28 cm each)

Now, save your file as my custom Grid.



